iNsAnItY

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Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
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Category:
F/F

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Catra & Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Minor or Background Relationship(s)

Characters:
Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Febuwhump 2021, Prompt Fic, Mind Control, Psychological Horror, Horror, Survival Horror, Eldritch, Eldritch Abomination, We're talking SCP-type shit, Nightmares, Nightmares of Drowning, Aquaphobia, is "being forced to fight your loved ones" a tag?, It is now, Being Forced to Fight Your Loved Ones, The Author Regrets Nothing, warning: title is really stupid and bland, But to be fair, finishing this killed my last three brain cells, author needs a nap, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Emotional Hurt No Comfort, Slow loss of identity, this is the second fic I wrote for this event with that as a major element, Tags Are Hard, no beta we die like Horde Prime, possible ooc, Author Is Sleep Deprived, Whump, Angst

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Part 1 of Febuwhump 2021

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by storythief11

Summary

After an expedition to a distant planet goes horribly wrong, Catra has to rescue her now-brainwashed wife from the eldritch horror that tore the planet to shreds. The problem is that she's running out of time: the longer Adora stays under the creature's control, the more of herself she loses, and it's only a matter of time before the creature gets Catra too.

Don't Speak

Chapter Notes

> This was originally supposed to be for the Febuwhump event, but I decided to turn the prompts into their own full-length fics and upload them in the order they would've been uploaded had I stuck with the event. This was one of only two She-Ra fics that I wrote for the event, the other being centered around Entrapta and Hordak with the prompt "I can't see". This fic's prompt was "mind control", but I gave it a distinctly...eldritch twist, shall we say.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Rocks crunched beneath Catra's feet as she made her way down a steep, sharp slope. Her breath frosted in the air - it was strangely cold here, and she didn't like it at all.

A distant crashing sound drew her attention. She spun around, breath briefly halting in her throat, but there was nothing there.

She kept going.

The slope began to even out. Up ahead, though, she could see where it fell away into darkness, forming a ravine that looked like some ancient giant had sliced into the ground with a knife. Fortunately, while it was deep, it wasn't very wide, and with a quick running start, she was able to jump across.

The land here was wide and bare, unlike the rest of the planet's rocky terrain. The only landmark was a downed spaceship resting in the middle.

Catra felt her hackles rise at the thought of crossing such a wide distance without cover, but she had no other choice.

She began to run. The layer of pebbles covering the earth began to thin until she was running on bare stone. She could see narrow

cracks, not too dissimilar to stains in a tree trunk or eyes, but despite the feeling of being watched that rose when she passed, she forced herself to look away.

After what felt like hours, she finally reached the ship. Wrenching the door open, she darted inside, sealing it closed behind her. She leaned against it, trying to catch her breath.

After briefly tugging at the door to make sure it would stay shut, Catra ran for the cockpit. The engine was dead, but she hoped that the batteries still had enough energy…

She almost cried in relief when the control panel booted up, but it was short-lived when she realized that she barely had enough power to do what she came here for.

She practically slammed in the passcode, then sent out a message to anyone who could hear.

"Mayday! Mayday! This planet is unsafe. I'm stranded here with my…" she hesitated. "With my wife, but she's been taken by something living here. Help us, but be careful. I don't think-"

The sudden screech of metal being torn apart filled her ears. She sent the message out and shut it down, then ducked under the console.

The silence that filled the ship would've lulled Catra into a false sense of security had this not happened before. Still, when the sound of footsteps began to rattle through the halls, she flinched and curled up a little tighter, pressing herself against the wall.

"Catra~" A familiar voice sang. "Catraaa~"

Catra bit back a hiss and tried to hold as still as she could.

The air almost seemed to freeze when the thing that was once Adora entered. All Catra could see of it was its legs; even if she could, she wouldn't have looked up, afraid of what she would see and unwilling to let her emotions overcome her should she need

to fight back. If she saw Adora's face, she might very well hesitate, and that could easily cost her her life.

The figure paced around, her boots clanking on the metal floor. Catra flinched at every sound and clapped a hand over her mouth, trying to keep from saying anything. She could feel the fur on her tail puffing up in fright.

After a while, the figure left, footsteps retreating down the hall. After hearing the loud screech of the spaceship door closing once more, Catra scurried out of her hiding spot and opened up the communicator.

There was a single message from Glimmer.

"Hang on, Catra. We're coming for you."

Chapter End Notes

I have many regrets, but this fic is not one of them.

Lights Under the Water

Chapter Notes

> Not really happy with this one, but I can't keep rewriting it, so I'm posting it.

The trek back was familiar but no less nerve-wracking. This place was wide and so dangerously dead, and Catra couldn't help but flinch at every sound.

She made it back from the barren plain, leaping across the ravine and scrambling up the rocky hill, disappearing into the tangled maze of spikes on the other end.

She navigated through the maze, eventually reaching the burnt-out husk of a tree. Scaling it with ease, she made her way to the top of the maze, dancing across the spikes until she reached a cave nestled into one of the sheer cliffs cradling the maze.

The interior of the cave was only slightly less barren than the world outside of it, and signs of life still flickered within - a pile of embers, a bag of supplies resting on an outcropping, a sleeping bag stretched out in the corner.

She coaxed the embers back to life before curling up against a wall, staring into the dim, flickering flames. Despite the sharp cave walls digging into her back, she soon found herself drifting off to sleep.

She dreamed that she was underwater. Her immediate reaction was to panic, scrabbling desperately for the surface, for air to fill her lungs, but she soon realized two things. The first was that her lungs didn’t ache for air; it was like she didn’t need to breathe at all. The second was that there was something much, much more concerning drifting around her in the dark.

She couldn't see it, but she could feel it; could feel its eyes scanning her, assessing her like a predator would its prey.

Her body stiffened, froze. She began to sink just a little deeper, no sign of a surface in sight. She poured all her energy into her limbs, but she couldn't move no matter how hard she tried.

A bolt of water shot past her and sent her spinning. She righted herself and began to swim once more, heart pounding. She had to get out, get out, *get out*-

Something struck her, grabbed her tail and dragged her down. She gasped and screamed, the water stealing her words as she kicked and pounded at whatever held her captive-

Blue lights, bright in the darkness of the water, lit up around her. Something swarmed past her, chasing away whatever held her under. She kicked free and swam away; far above, she could see the thin sheen of the surface-

Brace Yourself

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra woke with a sharp gasp, her lungs seizing and stuttering as they adjusted to reality.

She almost expected to wake up back on her ship or on Etheria, but no. She found herself inside of a ragged cave, and it took her a minute to remember what happened.

The crash. The creature. *Losing Adora.*

She clenched her fists, claws digging into the palms of her hands. *Don't think about that. It won't help.*

She stood shakily, gaze passing through the cave and then out at its entrance. No sign of anyone or anything, or even any trouble. Despite seemingly being a good thing, her hackles still rose. She grabbed her stuff and slipped out of the cave, making her way through the familiar maze. A bone-dry wind wound through the passages, ruffling her fur and whispering in her ears.

A sudden idea struck her, and she turned back to the tree. Scaling it once more, she began poking through the branches until she found what she was looking for - a sturdy core of a branch, straight enough to throw or use as a weapon.

Returning to the cave, she retrieved some twine from the supplies and a sharp rock from the ground. With a fair amount of cussing and effort, she was able to attach the rock to the branch, creating a makeshift spear. Finally, she had a weapon; she just had to hope that she never had to use it.

The water was thick and cold, and it drowned her. Its depths were unseeable, its surface unreachable, and she was caught in the

place in between, being pulled deeper no matter how hard she struggled for the surface.

She screamed a name that the water stole, and the water ripped out her voicebox in retribution. No matter how hard she fought back, it was stronger. The water would always win.

Chapter End Notes

This is way too short and way too bad for how long it took to write. Sorry, guys.

An Old and Forsaken Place

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Catra slipped across the planet's barren terrain. The skeletons of its previous inhabitants' might rusted and festered on the horizon in the form of grand, crumbling buildings.

She found herself in a valley, poking through an empty bunker.

A rumble shook the earth. Dust cascaded from the concrete ceiling. Catra grabbed her makeshift spear and brandished it, approaching the door with trembling hands.

"Who's there?" She called.

There was no response.

Catra stepped out the door. The ground shuddered again.

She climbed the hill behind the bunker. Shock clawed at her heart when she saw what lay on the other side. There stood a crumbling ruin of a fortress. Painted on its facade in peeling paint was the symbol of Horde Prime.

Catra approached cautiously. The door had seemingly collapsed in on itself.

The interior was as barren as the rest of the planet, with one exception - scattered on the floor were the withered, desiccated remains of dozens of Horde soldiers. Scrawled on the wall in paint the color of blood were seven words.

This is not a place of honor

Catra turned tail and ran for her life.

Chapter End Notes

AAAA why can't I write?!

Edit: oh hey, I just realized I uploaded this chapter on Friday the 13th. I'm sure that's a good sign. /s

Nothing Left in the Wake

Chapter Notes

> I know it's been years since this fic was last updated, and...honestly, that was entirely my fault. It took me a few years to work up the motivation and I lost 90% of my notes on how it was supposed to go, so when I decided to come back to it I had to improvise based on what I could find or remember. It's kind of rushed, but if I get the chance, I'll try to rewrite it.

It took Catra several days to work up the courage to leave again, and it was only her steadily-dwindling supplies that drove her out. She'd never been this rattled about anything before, but this was not Etheria. On Etheria, you at least somewhat knew what you expected. Anything could happen here.

She stumbled through the ruined cities that grew more and more familiar with each trip outside the cave. After breaking open what looked like a storefront, she managed to find preserved food that was likely already bad, but despite this fact and its flavor, she devoured it eagerly. With her most pressing concern no longer an issue, she found herself staring up at the crumbling buildings around her, wondering what became of their inhabitants.

Likely what became of those Horde soldiers and Adora, her mind supplied. The mere thought made her shudder, and she pushed it aside.

She gathered some more supplies and returned to the cave, adding them to the pile of slowly-dwindling resources in the corner. Time had begun to blur together, and despite her best attempts to keep track of it, she had no idea how long she'd been here. For all she knew, it could've been months or it could've been a week.

Where was Glimmer?

Catra curled up on the stone ledge that had become her bed and tried to sleep. It came surprisingly easy these days, but it was always light and rarely restful. It was all she had to do though, and she had the time.

Catra woke to find Adora standing over her, sword in hand. She rolled out of bed, narrowly avoiding a blow that likely would've cut her in half, and grabbed the spear propped against the cave wall. It was too brittle to stand up to the might of a sword, but maybe she could get a few hits in-

No, no she couldn't. This was her wife, this was *Adora*, who'd gone through hell to save her and never stopped believing that Catra could be more than just the person abuse had made her into. She couldn't hurt her.

Catra dodged another impact and ran for the door. Adora tromped behind her, her footsteps echoing on the cave floor. She was fast, but Catra knew what she was doing and where she was going. She jumped across the spires of the stone labyrinth and down the tree, vanishing into the twisting passages. Navigating them was almost an instinct now.

She couldn't go back now. Her one safe haven had been violated. Whatever had taken over Adora knew where she'd been hiding now. A feeling of hopelessness she hadn't felt since the crash overcame her. She had *nothing* once again except the clothes on her back.

A Way That Matters

Catra stumbled through the maze for minutes that bled into hours. The hours had begun to bleed into the first day when she heard footsteps behind her.

Catra froze, spear in hand. She spun around, but saw nothing except bare, barren rock. She scanned her surroundings warily.

"Adora?" she called.

There was no response.

She continued onward, deeper into the maze. Then she heard it again.

She didn't hesitate this time. Catra spun around, brandishing her spear. Lurking behind her was a familiar silhouette. The breath fled from her lungs. Catra turned tail and ran, the footsteps ringing loud and clear behind her. Gravel crunched beneath their feet as they ran, pushing deeper and deeper into the maze. The gravel gave way to hard stone, then back to gravel, and then to a soft, mosslike substance. Catra's surroundings slowly grew less and less familiar.

Then her steps slowed as she realized something. The footsteps were gone. She glanced over her shoulder. Adora stood on the edge of the moss, her expression blank. She took a step back, then another. The moss shimmered with strange patterns, which seemed to ripple and move the longer Catra stared at it. It might've been her imagination, but Adora - or whatever was controlling her, more accurately - seemed *frightened* of the moss.

Catra didn't have much time to think about that, though. She had to keep going before the creature changed its mind and kept up its pursuit. And...

...and maybe, if she wasn't crazy...maybe she'd finally found true safety, and if she could find the moss's source, she could free

Adora.

The Beast Below

Catra followed the beds of moss through the maze until sunset and well into the night. They covered the labyrinth's floor, thin in some places, thicker in others. The deeper she went, the more they began to creep up the walls, even covering some of the arches and landbridges running overhead. Patterns rippled across it like water where she touched it, mesmerizing and alien in equal measure.

Finally, the mouth of a cave rose in front of her. Catra peered inside; it descended into pitch black, like the maw of an unknown beast. The moss lined the walls of the cave's throat. They lit up where she stepped, allowing her to see what lay ahead of her.

The descent was steep and slippery, but the moss cushioned her occasional fall. Her breaths were shallow, and the sound's echoes were eaten by the thick overgrowth around her. Down and down she traveled, until her chest began to tighten and her lungs began to burn. Until she began to wonder if she was drawing closer and closer to the planet's burning, beating heart.

Finally, the cave opened out into a massive cavern, its ceiling lined with toothlike stalactites. Mushrooms and moss bloomed in the cracks, filling the space with dim luminescence. The cave's sides were impossible to see from where Catra stood, and the stone ledge she'd emerged onto was the only land visible. The remainder of the cave's floor was dominated by a veritable sea, black as night. The ledge descended into the water, which lapped gently at the stone.

Catra drew in a sharp breath. Her tail puffed up behind her. She smoothed it down. Something was watching her; its presence sent a shiver up her spine. It reminded her of the creature that took Adora from her, but the uncanniness felt less...*cruel*. It felt like it wanted her here, like it welcomed her presence, like it had guided...

...her...

The dreams. The lights under the water. Was this...?

"Hello?" Catra called.

Her voice echoed on the stone. There was no response. She looked around, but there was nothing. Just her and the watery abyss below.

Catra drew a deep breath and descended towards the water. She pressed a hand to its surface and called out again. Something rippled under the water's surface, and she scrambled backward with a hiss. Lights glimmered, dim but fluorescent, somewhere far below her.

She knew what she had to do now. Not that she wanted to do it, though.

She stood again and followed the ledge down to the water's surface. It flowed, thick and cool, around her ankles, and she grimaced. Another step took her up to her knees, then her waist, then her chest. She took a deep breath and plunged under the water's surface.

For a few moments, there was nothing except darkness and silence. Then the water warmed dramatically around her, and she opened her eyes to see herself surrounded by bright, glimmering lights. She looked down, down into the abyss-

A single, solitary light, bright as the midday Sun, loomed far beneath her. A chill crept up her spine as she realized it was an eye. Bubbles drifted from her parted lips; it felt like the eye could see right through her as easily as the water. Like it knew her. Like it'd been waiting for her all along.

Like it knew what brought her to the brink of desperation, and down into its domain.

A single word, a plea, a prayer, burned on the tip of Catra's tongue. She couldn't speak it, but the beast below her knew exactly what it was without her ever having to say.

Please.

The water surged around Catra. The lights swirled, pressing against her skin, warm and hard and insubstantial all at once. They pushed her upward, up and up and up, until she broke the surface. Catra drew in a thick, heaving, shuddering breath. The lights didn't stop; they lifted her further, into the air. The cavern's lights winked out all at once, and she kept going, further and further, until she was certain they'd have hit the ceiling by now. The lights swirled around her like a shield or a serpent, protecting her as they rose higher and higher and-

Her eyes snapped open (when had she closed them?). She stood in the maze, alone. The moss was withered and fading, near-lifeless. The cave was gone. But she was not alone.

Catra opened her hands and gazed down at her palms. Lights shimmered behind her eyelids, under her skin; it was power, unnatural power, but it was one she needed. She closed her hands into fists again and closed her eyes.

"Thank you," she whispered, her voice crackling like glass.

Ozymandias

Rocks crunched beneath Catra's feet as she made her way down a steep, sharp slope. Her breath frosted in the air, but she didn't mind. The warmth burning in her chest chased away the worst of its bite.

A crashing sound up ahead drew her attention. She couldn't see Adora, but she could *feel* her presence just as well. She was on the run, and the thrill of the chase was strong enough to almost make Catra forget that the prey she was pursuing was her wife.

The slope began to even out. Up ahead, she could see where it fell away into darkness, forming a ravine that looked like some ancient giant had sliced into the ground with a knife. Adora's retreating figure was already on the other side, heading towards the spaceship. Catra leapt over the ravine with no fear of falling; her feet scraped the ground on the other side.

After what felt like hours, she finally reached the ship. It was the only cover on the open ground, the only place Adora could've gone. Catra flung the door open, barely even seeming to touch it to do so. She could hear her heartbeat drumming in her ears, and almost taste Adora's fear - no, not Adora's. The creature controlling her.

Catra smirked. It had a right to be scared now.

"Adora~" Catra sang. "Come on out."

Silence greeted her. She scanned her surroundings. Where was there to hide...?

Where had *she* hid in this same situation what felt like years ago now?

Catra approached the console. She leaned down, scanning the darkness underneath. A familiar pair of eyes met hers. Catra grinned.

"Hey, Adora."

Adora flung a steel plate at Catra, who caught it with ease. It crumpled like a tin can in her grip. Adora's eyes were wide with fear.

"Catra, no!" she cried, but the tone, the inclination was off. It wasn't Adora speaking. Catra knew that for a fact.

She lunged at the creature, grabbed Adora by her shoulders. The energy within Catra rose up like the tide within her, flowed from her into Adora. She could feel its hatred, its fury at the thing in Adora's mind for destroying all it had, all it was, all it had ever loved. She could feel its pity for her, if such a thing was possible for something as old as a planet, knowing that Catra was suffering a smaller, more pitiful version of the same thing as it. Catra stared what was once Adora dead in the eyes, bathing in its fear, watching its pupils dilate and the red light within slowly, slowly morph into blue.

Shadows crept in on the corners of her mind. Adora's eyes slid shut; her body fell to the ground, limp. An empty puppet with cut strings. Catra leaned against the remains of the pilot's seat, her eyelids heavy. The cold fire within her was gone, its purpose fulfilled. She smiled, a true, genuine smile, the first in so long. Then her eyes slipped closed, and she fell into the abyss.

"Catra! *Catra!*"

Catra jolted awake. There was a figure looming over her, a figure her mind told her not to fear but her instincts told her to hurt. She lashed out, claws reaching for the figure's face, but they grabbed her wrists and held them still.

"It's me! It's Adora!"

Her vision cleared, her mind with it. The eyes staring down at her were not rapt with madness, but with shock and horror and love.

"A-Adora?"

The warrior smiled softly. "Hey, Kitty."

She swatted at her arm for that nickname, making her chuckle, before sitting up. Her head spun, but she soon realized that she was no longer in the wreck; rather, she was out in the open, staring up at the sky.

"What happened?" She asked.

Adora shrugged. "I don't know. The last thing I remember was crashing the ship and finding the cave, then waking up out here."

"Catra?"

She shook her head, returning her gaze to her wife and giving her a weak smile. "Sorry. I got distracted."

Adora looked suspicious, but said nothing.

They waited by the ruin until the engines of their friends' ship rumbled in the distance, and upon finally leaving its atmosphere and vanishing into space, there was nothing any of them could do to convince Catra to talk.

Somewhere deep inside her, she could feel the cold fire burning away, faint and weak and tender as an old wound.

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